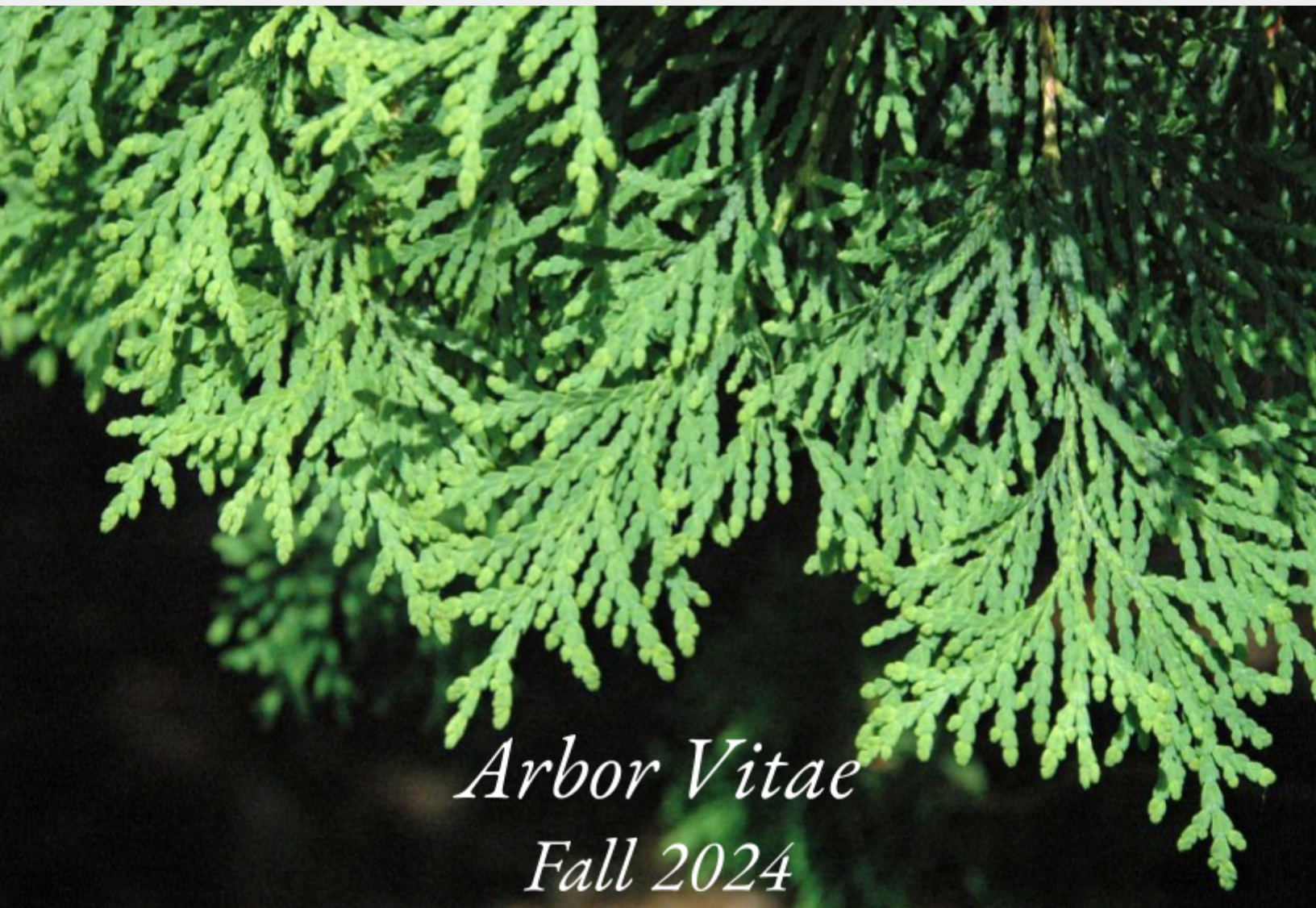




Arbor Vitae
Fall 2024

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A Letter from the Editor

Dear Reader,

Since the beginning of the semester this fall, *Arbor Vitae* has undergone many changes. First of all, there's the name itself. This is our first semester as *Arbor Vitae*, which means "Tree of Life" in Latin and happens to include the name of our university's home city of Ann Arbor. We also welcomed new writers this semester, with two students publishing their excellent work on our pages for the first time. Finally, we inhabited a new meeting space, using the first floor of the Michigan Christian Study Center as our new home base, and presenting our work to an audience of fellow students at a Friday lunch talk.

We're also grateful for the ways things have stayed the same this semester. Student writers remained committed to publishing high-quality, personal, and purposeful writing on a variety of subjects. Our editing process was still marked by incisive feedback, encouragement, and healthy debate. Grammarly is still the most effective writing assistant despite the fast-approaching AI takeover. Most importantly, writers continued to grow in love for our Savior, the author and perfecter of our faith.

The Fall 2024 edition features no shortage of challenging topics. Our writers tackle political victory, pride, planning, and more by weaving Scripture, personal experiences, and reason together. Though the pieces differ substantially in topic and scope, a hope for new creation, anchored in the resurrection of Jesus, animates each one. Throughout this semester's edition, writers yearn for themselves, the church, and the world to be renewed by the sanctifying work of the Holy Spirit. Our prayer is that our writing may refresh, inspire, and challenge you to contemplate our Creator, the only true "Tree of Life," and meditate on His holy renewal.

We thank you for spending your time with us this semester and pray that God may bless you in this new year.

Yours in Christ,

Brady Nichols

Editor-in-Chief



Thoughts on Pride - A Hidden Enemy

Ellie Manly

Therefore it says, "God opposes the proud but gives grace to the humble." James 4:6 ESV

Pride is certainly a word thrown around in the church quite a bit. I hear it often, however, I've had little understanding of what it looks like in my day-to-day life. For a long time, I felt I did not need to understand pride. How could someone like me, who already has consistently low self-esteem and daily battles with depression and anxiety, need to consider how pride wrecks my life? I thought I could really use some more of it, if anything. For a long time hearing the word pride made my bones itch, like hearing a fire and brimstone preacher accuse me. So, if you, the reader, are coming to this with a similar unfamiliarity with pride, you are certainly not alone.

It is no wonder that when a mentor responded to me with, "I wonder if it's a pride thing" after I poured my heart out in all its complexity, I was stopped in my tracks. But the Spirit began to soften my heart in the places it was guarded. If my goal was to find a solution to my low self-esteem, pride wasn't working.

I began to understand the broken self-concept as a two-sided coin: pride and self-hatred work hand in hand. They are both responses to a story where the love of God is not all-consuming enough for me. Therefore in order to address pride I must address self hatred.

Self-hatred says nothing makes me capable of being loved, and therefore there is no possible way I could ever love myself. Self-hatred leads to isolation and defeat.



The “aha” came for me when I realized that pride responds to the same story: I am not loved unless I have it all together. I am not loved without my popularity, my religiosity, my grades, my networking, my emotional intelligence, my kindness as a friend, my empathy, my loyalty, etc. Traits that turn into sources of pride can be unique for everyone but when you get down to the root of it, pride grows from not knowing...*truly living and experiencing*...unconditional love. Pride has no room for unconditional love. Pride breeds anxiety because surrendering the masks of capability I put on feels like death. And what is underneath? When I finally looked honestly, all I saw was a deep hole of self-hatred. What then, was I to do with that realization? Is there a solution? Or, maybe even more hopeful, is there an invitation God has for me? In this pit where I am at the end of myself is exactly where I find Jesus, with open arms and a smile of delight. He is inviting me to turn to him, the only one who has what I truly need: overwhelming and unconditional love.

“While we were still enemies, Christ died for us.” Romans 5:8 ESV

Jesus is the solution to the deadly cycle. Because his ultimate act of fearless love is a definitive answer to that deep hole of self-hatred that compels me to hide from the world. He speaks the truth to me: *Beloved, you may not see it, but I do. What makes you lovable is the fact that I made you. Nothing more, nothing less. And that you, the one you are not proud of, I died for. I chose you.*”

There is something entirely refreshing about finally laying down the performance I am so used to maintaining. By receiving true healing, I know in my deepest place that I am loved by the name above all names. This is the key to true humility. Then, I can live out of my true self - not my prideful self - more and more.

But how do I live with this knowledge? Is there such a thing as Godly pride?



The Bible does speak of “boasting.” Surprisingly though, it isn’t just as a potential roadblock to living as we are meant to. Instead, Paul talks about redirecting our pride as a practice for worship! The distinction: boasting in the Lord.

“Let the one who boasts, boast in the Lord!” 2 Corinthians 10:17 ESV

This verse helped me understand that the Lord has made me with so much detail and affection, bearing his image is an act of worship! Cursing my image (external or internal), is cursing the one who created it. If I am to have pride, I can replace my misdirected pride with pride that the Lord is my Creator, my Lover, and the One who holds my worth...that I am chosen, unconditionally loved, seen, and completely known. That is the God I love in return.

When God gives me my strengths, they are no longer mine to maintain, but mine to worship with.

When God gives me my weaknesses, they are no longer mine to curse, but my source of dependence upon God:

“Therefore I will boast all the more gladly about my weaknesses, so that Christ’s power may rest on me.”

2 Corinthians 12:9 NIV



Loving Strangers

Jamauri Bryan

Growing up, I had a unique view of what it meant to be “American.” My family immigrated to the United States from Jamaica several years before I was born. Most of my extended family and both my parents grew up outside of the US. Meanwhile, I was born and raised in the sunny suburbs of Fort Lauderdale, Florida. As a child of Jamaican immigrants, I was often expected to bridge Jamaican and American cultures. To me, this meant acknowledging and respecting my Jamaican roots while adopting and living by Western standards. There was a duality to my identity, and I never really realized how valuable that would be until much later in my life.

In the book of Leviticus, the Lord addresses the Israelites after saving them from their Egyptian captives. Leviticus 19:33-34 (ESV) says the following: *“When a stranger sojourns with you in your land, you shall not do him wrong. You shall treat the stranger who sojourns with you as the native among you, and you shall love him as yourself, for you were strangers in the land of Egypt: I am the Lord your God.”*

When I think of this verse, I think about the kindness and grace that my family was shown in the US as they immigrated to start a new life. Throughout my higher education journey, I’ve been able to engage with “strangers” from across the globe. As I continue to act on the principles outlined in Leviticus, here are two things that I’ve learned while serving in ministry with the international community.



1. Practice Compassion and Communication

In the Book of James, James, the brother of Jesus, addresses the 12 tribes of Israel. Specifically, James speaks on direct actions that the audience can take to live a life of holiness and effectively practice their faith. Let's look at James 1:19-20 (ESV), "*Know this, my beloved brothers: let every person be quick to hear, slow to speak, slow to anger; for the anger of man does not produce the righteousness of God.*"

It's very common for people to be unsure of things they are unfamiliar with. For many international students and immigrants, this may be their first time navigating new social settings and customs. Rather than reacting with frustration or impatience, we are called to extend grace and understanding.

I was reminded of this on a recent road trip to Toronto with some friends. While exploring the city, we visited a board game café and decided to play a round of *Taboo*. For those who aren't familiar, the game involves describing a word without using a list of forbidden "taboo" words while your team tries to guess it. It's a fast-paced game that relies on a understanding of vocabulary and cultural context.

One of my friends, Shinji, who is Japanese, struggled during the game. Some of the words were completely unfamiliar to him, and even when he understood them, he had trouble thinking of ways to describe them in English. At first, the rest of us didn't realize how challenging it must have been for him, but as we noticed his frustration, we decided to make some adjustments. We removed the more difficult words from the deck and encouraged Shinji to take his time when it was his turn. These small acts of grace transformed what could have been an uncomfortable experience into one filled with laughter and enjoyment.



That evening reminded me how important it is to be patient and compassionate with those who are navigating unfamiliar territory. It's easy to get caught up in the moment and expect others to adapt quickly, but as followers of Christ, we are called to meet people where they are and extend grace, just as it has been extended to us.

2. Show Intentionality

Many foreign students come to the U.S. to study without much community or a strong grasp of English. Intentionality allows us to go beyond small greetings and truly invest ourselves in the lives of others. In Philippians 2:3-4, Paul speaks on the concept of humility, *“Do nothing from selfish ambition or conceit, but in humility count others more significant than yourselves. Let each of you look not only to his own interests, but also the interests of others.”*

Intentionality and humility are pivotal tools Christians can use to connect with the strangers in their lives. For example, I'm a member of Bridges International, an international student ministry at the University of Michigan. One of the most memorable ministry experiences that I had with Bridges was this past fall at our Diwali dinner. Diwali, The Festival of Lights, is one of the most important celebrations in Indian culture.

The idea to host a dinner came from our Indian students, who wanted to share a piece of their culture with the rest of the group. On a chilly evening in October, we came together to share a meal that included traditional Indian dishes like biryani, samosas, and gulab jamun. Our Indian friends shared stories about the traditions they practiced back home and explained the customs of the holiday.



For many of us, it was the first time celebrating Diwali, and it was a wonderful opportunity to learn and celebrate with our friends.

By hosting the dinner, we weren't just creating a space for our Indian students to feel seen and valued—we were also inviting ourselves to learn and grow through their experiences. Intentionality in ministry often looks like this: listening to the needs and ideas of others, supporting them, and bringing it all back to the gospel message.

Conclusion

The call to love strangers is not merely a suggestion but a command rooted in God's character and His actions toward us. As believers, we can extend the same grace, patience, and intentionality that Christ has shown to us. Whether it's through small acts of compassion or through acts of intentionality, we can be living examples of God's love to those who are far from home. In a world often divided by differences, this kind of hospitality can shine as a light, pointing others to the ultimate hope we have in Christ.



The Case for Church

Brady Nichols

I returned to Ann Arbor this fall for my third year of college after eight months without a home church, by far the longest time I've ever spent without a consistent community of believers. I spent the second semester of my second year studying abroad in Spain, where there were few Protestant churches, and where the Catholic church has a fraught history of alignment with the fascist sect of Spanish politics. These factors made it tough for me to justify integrating myself into a church, not to mention that I was in Spain and there was a lot to do, especially on weekends. I didn't attend church much in Spain.

After four months abroad, I came home to Michigan for a week before shipping out to Washington, DC for my summer internship. There I explored churches for a couple of weeks before finding an Anglican congregation that I decided to attend. Even so, with two of my twelve weeks in DC occupied by church hunting and a couple of other Sunday mornings when I couldn't muster the strength for an hour-long journey on the Metro, I ended up attending too few services to get connected.

I must admit, there were some perks to not having a consistent church for eight months. I got to curate my own theological experience completely by consuming only the Christian podcasts and books I found most enjoyable. I saved time and energy usually spent on making small talk before and after services, and instead felt perfectly content bolting from the few services I attended without



speaking to anyone. There truly were times when I felt that going without church was easier and even better.

However, despite its enhancement of my experience as a passive consumer of Christian content, whether through my earbuds or my pew in the back of the sanctuary, churchlessness deprived me of the relationships, opportunities, and even inconveniences that make Christian life whole. Churchgoing has connected me with a community like nothing else in college. Never before have I been responsible for remembering as many baby due dates, birthdays, and names as I have since joining my church in Ann Arbor. In a sea of twenty-somethings, the church has blessed me with intergenerational friendships that have helped me contemplate my future and given me examples of excellent spouses, employees, friends, and neighbors to admire.

The most beautiful thing about church is that it's not all sunshine and rainbows. We Gen-Zers have a hard time dealing with tragedy, often collapsing into toxic positivity or nihilism to avoid facing up to the ugliness of living in a broken world. At church, however, I get to sit with people as they discuss mental health struggles, diseases, and dissatisfaction. I get to provide counsel and comfort in the face of broken friendships, even friendships formed and maintained within the church itself. I get to rally around my pastor as he continues to deal with the consequences of a devastating house fire. I get to plead with God for relief from suffering on behalf of other members, the university, and our world. I get to bear the burdens of others as they bear mine. And they do bear mine. I am indebted to so many sisters and brothers for their wisdom, patience, and love in dealing with my personal crises.

This type of co-dependence takes effort. It takes awkward conversations, vulnerability, and the sacrifice of time, money, and emotional bandwidth. But over the last eight months, I've realized these



things are what we're made for. We are meant to share everything in common, to weep with those who weep, to mourn with those who mourn. We are blessed by the wonderful truth that our lives are bound up with one another in Christ, that we are one body. The manifest beauty of Jesus' redemptive work is our love for one another. Heaven meets Earth in this, and it will be more perfect in the end.

My church isn't perfect. Nobody's church is, and goodness knows most are far from it. My experience over the past eight months has not blinded me to that. But my life as a Christian is incomplete without a body of believers. Let us never forget God's gracious gift of the church to us.



Daily Bread in a World of Planning

Hannah Young

As a college student, there is a lot of pressure to carefully plan out each step during your undergraduate career, so that you might craft the perfect resume to wow an interview committee, complete all of your coursework, juggle summer internships, campus jobs, clubs, and even plan out all of your meals, workouts, and social events. It's a pressure fueled by fear of uncertainty about the future and cast upon every student on campus, only producing short-term satisfaction before you're consumed by the next lurking task that will accumulate anxiety and demand all of your attention. You might be asking yourself, maybe, if I obtain control over these areas of my life, be it school, careers, relationships, or finances, amongst others, I will finally feel secure and satisfied? Maybe, if I carefully plan out all four years of college and follow that plan without any deviation, I will achieve every desire in my heart? What if God is calling me into these desires? Shouldn't I make sure that I plan very carefully to fulfill them if it's what God wants for me?

It's easy to allow yourself to spiral when considering all your future holds, and how you might somehow mess it all up. It can feel overwhelming, like putting together a puzzle with many small pieces while watching time tick off a clock, scrambling to make everything fit together, and watching the puzzles of those around you come together more quickly or reveal pictures more beautiful than yours. Needless to say, the pressure is on to set yourself up for success in your adult life when you come to college. Extra tensions may arise when considering what God has for you in this season and how you might "help" God to meet this end, leading to self-reliant tendencies. However, God speaks against



society's idealization of self-sufficiency in a radical way, stating that, "I am the vine; you are the branches. Whoever abides in me, and I in him, he it is that bears much fruit, for apart from me you can do nothing" (John 15:5 ESV). While it might seem like you can maintain control over how your life plays out, God emphasizes here that apart from Him our lives are fruitless. No matter what it seems like we might be able to achieve on our own, God's provision is far more abundant, faithful, loving, and unfailing.

Scripture recounts numerous examples of God's provision for His people. One powerful example of God's consistent and faithful provision is found woven throughout the book of Exodus, which tells the story of God delivering the Israelites out of slavery in Egypt. After their liberation and while the Israelites spent forty long years wandering in the wilderness before God led them to the promised land, God continuously cared for them, one way being through manna that He provided daily. While the Israelites' grumbled and wished they could return to Egypt as slaves again instead of wandering, "then the LORD said to Moses, "Behold, I am about to rain bread from heaven for you, and the people shall go out and gather a day's portion every day..." (Exodus 16:4 ESV). The Lord heard the Israelites' need for food, and fulfilled exactly this need. Beyond merely fulfilling the need, God gave the people clear instructions on how to obtain the food. And "the LORD has commanded: 'Gather of it, each one of you, as much as he can eat. You shall each take an omer, according to the number of the persons that each of you has in his tent. And the people of Israel did so. They gathered, some more, some less. But when they measured it with an omer, whoever gathered much had nothing left over, and whoever gathered little had no lack. Each of them gathered as much as he could eat" (Exodus 16:16-18 ESV). God is so very intentional with the Israelite people, recognizing their basic need for food, but



also considering each individual person and the degree of hunger that they had, so that each person was given just the right amount to eat. However, the manna wasn't an event confined to one day, but was rather a consistent and tangible product of God's care for the Israelites, as "The people of Israel ate the manna forty years, till they came to a habitable land" (Exodus 16:35 ESV). God perfectly saw and met the needs of each Israelite as they wandered; they needed only to be fully reliant on Him, not on themselves, for this provision.

Later in scripture, God sends his one and only son, Jesus, to Earth as fully man and fully God to live amongst His people. During Jesus' ministry, Jesus declares, "I am the bread of life. Your fathers ate the manna in the wilderness, and they died. This is the bread that comes down from heaven, so that one may eat of it and not die. I am the living bread that came down from heaven. If anyone eats of this bread, he will live forever. And the bread that I will give for the life of the world is my flesh" (John 6:48 ESV). Jesus compares himself to the daily bread that God rained down from heaven for the Israelites while they were wandering in the wilderness. This time, however, the bread Jesus is talking about doesn't satisfy the people's daily Earthly hunger, but rather their eternal spiritual hunger. While God's provision for the Israelites was gracious and satisfied their needs at the time, now we have access to the bread of life, Jesus, through the Holy Spirit which was given to us through His death, burial, and resurrection.

As seen in scripture, God has already provided eternal salvation for each and every soul that declares Him Lord, while also providing for every earthly need along the way, while we need only to "Trust in the LORD with all your heart, and do not lean on your own understanding. In all your ways acknowledge him, and he will make straight your paths" (Proverbs 3:5-6 ESV). God warns us not to fall



into the trap of thinking we are perfectly self-sufficient. After all, we are all human and fallible.

However, God doesn't work in these confines, and can and will sustain you. While planning is a fight for consistency, Jesus is the only true constant. This is great news, but difficult to put into practice when the pressures of the world say that you can only achieve what you desire if you do it yourself.

Ultimately, we must find the balance between trust in God and practical planning. God calls us into faithful stewardship of every resource He has blessed us with, "as each has received a gift, use it to serve one another, as good stewards of God's varied grace" (1 Peter 4:10 ESV). He has entrusted each of us with His creation as a gift, and as such, we must wisely and generously take care of each blessing, as they are all ultimately owned by God who promises to continuously and graciously fulfill our every need. We must trust that God is good and sufficient to sustain us, but this doesn't mean that planning is inherently bad. We must faithfully utilize the gifts and opportunities to serve that God has provided to us. Thus, God doesn't tell us not to plan at all. At the end of the day, there's a split chance you pass that exam next week, you get the job, or you secure the perfect housing lease. However, there's a 100% chance you come face to face with the Lord. In fact, we must prepare ourselves for this time.

Beautifully for us, while the world tells us that we need to have a plan A, plan B, and a plan C, the truth is that there's only one thing we need to figure out in our lives: that God is our Lord and Savior, that Jesus is the son of God who came to this earth as the perfect living sacrifice, who died a sinner's death so that we may have the hope of eternal life and forgiveness of our sins through His blood that he so freely shed for each of us.

This preparation includes a continual surrender of our heart and allowing God to transform it to His will, a unique process to each of us, and one that we can only achieve with God's help. Through



prayer and gratitude, practice putting your trust in God for every one of your needs. Thank God for all the ways that He has already provided for you, and ask that He provides for you again. Another practical step to take is to practice planning with open hands. While it may be difficult in all situations, embrace uncertainty as a way to further rely on God. Sit in the comfort only God can provide while you wait to see how He will fulfill your every need in His time. Often, when something seemingly goes wrong in your life, God has something much better to offer you when your heart is ready for it. Don't hold onto anything too tightly, but rather be ready to accept whatever God has in store for you next. One final suggestion is to practice resting in God's sovereignty and take part in sabbath rest. God himself rested on the seventh day and has granted us this day each week to recharge our mind, body, and soul for the week to come without worrying about what the next day will bring. Use this day to reflect on God's provision throughout the previous week and enjoy the freedom from planning the next week and the anxieties it could bring.

God has provided for every need of every generation before and will continue to provide for every need of every generation to come. His provision doesn't skip us! God wants a relationship with us in which we surrender control to Him and live in the present, delighting in His creation, while preparing ourselves to meet Him face-to-face. His daily bread is now more than just food, but rather is a symbol of His careful and consistent provision in our lives.



Careerism is Ruining College. Christians Can Model a Better Way.

Brady Nichols

A recent New York Times [op-ed](#) by Isabella Glassman, a 2023 graduate of the University of Pennsylvania, lamented the chokehold professional development culture has on today's elite universities. Glassman begins by describing the idyllic vision of college she took to campus her freshman year, complete with potluck picnics, late nights listening to Taylor Swift, and Quidditch. She then recounts her disillusionment with the "pre-professional culture" she encountered upon arrival, characterized by a narrow set of viable career choices and hypercompetitive admissions to student organizations. These problems are hardly unique to the University of Pennsylvania. Many of Glassman's observations about her classmates' obsessions with big tech, finance, and summer internships could easily be applied to the professional development landscape at the University of Michigan. The most prestigious clubs on campus often have extensive applications, multiple rounds of interviews, and selective acceptance rates. Students from all majors and backgrounds throw their hats in the ring for competitive consulting internships in America's largest cities, spending months stressing over interviews and resumes. Every success is euphoric, and every failure is equally gut-wrenching. Often, missing out on a crucial opportunity feels like throwing an entire future away, definitively closing the door on a path to the good life. This cuts to the core of the very identities of kids who have grown up being told they can do anything.

Glassman points to parental pressure and economic conditions as core drivers of pre-professional anxiety among college students. To be sure, stagnant real wages and the culture of



family achievement are major stressors. These factors, however, do not fully explain the rampant obsession with career achievement that pervades college campuses. After all, students at elite universities are better equipped than anyone to withstand turbulent economic times, as college-educated adults tend to earn higher wages and grow up in wealthier households to begin with. Moreover, parental pressure has been ubiquitous for high-achieving students since there have been students. The phenomenon Glassman highlights, however, has intensified greatly in recent years. The root cause of our career crises is not our parents nor the economy, but a struggle over the purpose and significance of work.

Defining career success properly requires an understanding of our work's purpose. After all, whether our work is good or bad depends on what our work is supposed to be for. Lamentably, reflection on purpose in professional pursuits is sorely lacking among most students I've encountered. Many of us absorb a culturally prevalent narrative about work, where work is designed to facilitate a future where we won't have to labor anymore. Then, the story goes, we'll finally be able to enjoy the fruits of our labor and freely pursue the real purpose of our lives. So we pay it forward, sacrificing our mental health, relationships, and passions in service of an idyllic (hopefully early!) retirement. In this vision, work is good insofar as it moves us toward security, stability, and self-sufficiency. This idea is hardly unique to college students today; it's the American dream, and plenty of fully-formed adults operate from similar assumptions. The problem, as Glassman shows us, is that this dream is ultimately suffocating, leading even highly talented college students with bright futures to engage the here and now with trepidation instead of hopeful resolve.



Fortunately, the Christian tradition has a theology of work that contrasts starkly with the American dream and is much older, deeper, and more robust than anything on offer in the modern world. According to a Christian vision, work has been part of the human experience since the creation of the universe, when God entrusted human beings with cultivating the world. Genesis 1:28 (NIV) says God “*blessed [human beings] and said to them, “Be fruitful and increase in number; fill the earth and subdue it. Rule over the fish in the sea and the birds in the sky and over every living creature that moves on the ground.”* From the very beginning, humans have occupied a special place in the created order as rulers and subduers of the earth. Later, in Genesis 2, God brings all the animals of the earth to man to be named, making man a co-creator with him and involving him in His work. When we name, rule, and subdue, we mirror God’s loving act of creation and fulfill our role as God’s image on earth. This has enormous implications for how we approach our work. First, we must recognize that work is not a curse. Rather, it is a loving and gracious gift from our Creator, whereby he allows us to participate in His creative power. Second, we should understand that our work ultimately belongs to God, as it is His perfect creativity that enables us to exercise our gifts and talents.

The ideal picture of human work we receive in Genesis 1-2 is altered in Genesis 3, where human sin corrupts creation, bringing humanity into an adversarial relationship with its work. In Genesis 3:17-19 (NIV), God pronounces judgment on Adam for his sin, saying “*Cursed is the ground because of you; through painful toil you will eat food from it all the days of your life. It will produce thorns and thistles for you, and you will eat the plants of the field. By the sweat of your brow you will eat your food until you return to the ground since from it you were taken; for dust you are and to dust you will return.*” Closely linked to human finitude (“for dust you are”) comes a relationship between humans



and work of toil, pain, and sweat. This vision of work will be much more familiar to University of Michigan students, who are no strangers to toil. It is undeniable that the work we do is often difficult, draining, and discouraging. What is less clear in our daily lives, however, is that according to Genesis 1-2, *it was not supposed to be this way*. The strife we experience as we work is not inherent in the nature of work itself, but rather a result of the corruption of the world by human sin. Read together, Genesis 1, 2, and 3 paint a picture of work that both extols the goodness and God-giveness of work and explains the frustrations our work is apt to produce.

The first three chapters of the Bible show us that work has a beautiful design as a collaboration with our Creator that has been tainted by human sin. The purpose of work, then, far from earning large paychecks or amassing awards and accomplishments, is the glorification of God through engagement with his creation in alignment with his design. The New Testament provides us with insight as to what this purpose looks like in action. In Matthew 6:24 (NIV), Jesus offers us practical wisdom for our relationship with money as part of his Sermon on the Mount. Jesus states quite plainly that we “*cannot serve both God and money*” as part of a larger discourse on heavenly and earthly treasures. The master in our lives, according to Jesus, is to be God, not money. This point is pressed further in Matthew 19:16-22 (NIV), where Jesus responds to a rich young man eager to know how to inherit eternal life by calling him to “*go, sell what you have and give to the poor, and you will have treasure in heaven; and come, follow Me.*” These commands are challenging, as they present a radical vision of detachment from money compared to most of our surrounding culture. This culture also seeps into Christian spaces, where money is often treated as a morally neutral byproduct of success rather than something whose love is the “*root of all evil,*” (1 Timothy 6:10 NIV). When seeking to



follow Jesus in our careers, it's clear that following God's calling, and not money, is our primary mission.

The apostle Paul's letters to the early church emphasize the dignity of work in a shockingly egalitarian manner for his time. Household codes, documents that detailed the responsibilities of each member of the family to each other and the surrounding world, were commonly written as didactic tools in the Roman Empire. Most of these writings featured little to no instructions for people on the lower rungs of the social ladder, like women, children, and slaves. Paul, however, imitates this style of writing on multiple occasions with important twists. Strikingly, Paul addresses slaves directly throughout his writing, advising them to work diligently as if for Christ, not for men. Ephesians 6:5-6 (NIV), for example, states it this way: "*Slaves, obey your earthly masters with respect and fear, and with sincerity of heart, just as you would obey Christ. Obey them not only to win their favor when their eye is on you, but as slaves of Christ, doing the will of God from your heart.*" Though these verses at first glance appear to endorse the institution of slavery, Paul advises slaves who can gain their freedom to do so in other writings (1 Corinthians 7:21) and subverts slavery in his letter to Philemon. Rather, in these household codes Paul is dignifying the humanity of slaves by reminding them that even their low social position is a place to carry out "*the will of God*" rather than the will of human beings. Paul's claim here is still subversive today. American culture, idolatrous of achievement and status, scorns the idea that all work, regardless of prestige, is worthy of praise and effort.

Paul's writing not only values all forms of work, however meager, but it also embraces the variety of gifts God has instilled in his people to serve his kingdom. Nowhere is this more salient than in Romans 12, where Paul discusses the diversity and necessity of the gifts God bestows on his people.



Romans 12: 6-8 (NIV) reads “*We have different gifts, according to the grace given to each of us. If your gift is prophesying, then prophesy in accordance with your faith; if it is serving, then serve; if it is teaching, then teach; if it is to encourage, then give encouragement; if it is giving, then give generously; if it is to lead, do it diligently; if it is to show mercy, do it cheerfully.*” Here Paul is discussing gifts given for the benefit of the church, but his point can easily be extended to different gifts and contexts. Our professional lives offer plenty of opportunities to teach, encourage, serve, lead, and show mercy. Moreover, using the specific gifts God has bestowed on us is an exercise in humility. The above passage is preceded by Romans 12:3, which admonishes believers not to think of themselves more highly than they ought. In our professional lives, then, we should both seek to use our unique gifts earnestly for the good of the kingdom and humbly recognize our limitations as fallen human beings.

The Christian view of work also serves to direct us to our ultimate hope in the renewal of creation through Christ. The final two chapters of the Bible, Revelation 21-22, paint a picture of the coming “*new Jerusalem*” (Revelation 21:2 NIV) where the Lord will dwell with his people and wipe every tear from their eyes once and for all. Here Eden is restored, not forgotten, and the tree of life now bears fruit that will never bring a curse (Revelation 22:2-3 NIV). Most notably for this article, humans remain “servants” to God, and maintain their eternal vocation of glorifying him. Simply put, we will still have a job to do in the New Creation. All the work we do in the here and now mirrors this wondrous, eternal vocation that we wait hopefully to receive in full.

Glassman’s article offers an incisive assessment of the professional culture that pervades elite universities. It aptly characterizes the way work consumes student life, crowding out activities and relationships that are meant to be part of the college experience. What it doesn’t lay out, however, is a



comprehensive solution to the problems it presents. The Christian vision of work does just that. It gives us a healthy understanding of the purpose and dignity of work while encouraging excellence for the glory of God, not ourselves. All of this falls under the cross of Christ, which provides us with ultimate hope that work done for the kingdom of heaven will not be in vain. Christian college students and ministries have an excellent opportunity, equipped with a robust theology of work, to embody a transformed work ethic at our universities. Students must approach their work diligently and humbly, earnestly seeking to exercise their gifts for the good of the world rather than pursuing money, power, or prestige. Spiritual leaders and mentors must encourage students to excel in their work while recognizing its proper relationship to their identities. All Christians on campus should counter the prevailing culture by striving to embody a healthy, whole understanding of what work is meant to be and point people to the ultimate Christian hope in the New Creation.

